driving along the watershed where the armour was facing off. We had taken off from Delhi at 0700 hours, with an altitude of 800 feet and temperature of 10 degrees Celsius. Within three hours, we were at Rechin La, with an altitude of 18,000 feet and temperature of minus 20 degrees. I went into the tents and shelters pitched on the hillsides, shared a cup of tea and spoke to the tank crews, who even in their wildest dreams had not imagined that they would be deployed at such heights. We stood at the pass in full view of the PLA armour, and I am sure they would have learnt later that it was the Army Chief who had visited. At the helipad, just before returning, I spoke to as many troops who were off-duty and told them what a splendid job they were doing. I also distributed some mithai, fresh from Delhi, for Christmas. I don't know whether I was able to boost their morale or not, but after seeing them, my morale was definitely boosted, to see that our men are strong, capable, and notwithstanding the harsh terrain and climate that they were facing on a daily basis, they were still cheerful and welcoming, full of smiles. Josh was high. I came back very satisfied and I felt good about our Army as a whole. We are very lucky to have in our frontline troops, hardy soldiers who are ready to brave any kind of adversity. And then it was back again to Delhi, which we reached by about 1430 hours, time enough to freshen up and off to the PM's residence at 1630 hours where I was to give a briefing to the CCS, who were surprised to see me as they were just then watching news of my visit on the TV. The visit served me in good stead as I was able to brief the CCS with more confidence

26 January Republic Day celebrations kept us busy but we convened a need-to-know basis CSG meeting at the RM's residence on Akbar Road on 27 Jan. Only the RM, EAM, NSA and COAS (myself) and from the staff side, the FS,

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